Go-Bag Checklist

Use this list to pack what your household needs to leave quickly. Tailor every bag to each person's health, age, abilities, language, animals, local hazards, and destination—and to what that person can safely carry.

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Leave when officials say to leave. A go-bag supports an evacuation; it is never a reason to delay. Follow current local instructions about routes, shelters, allowed items, and supplies.

Household/member: _____ Bag number: ____ of ____

Likely destination or meeting place: _____

1. EVERYDAY ESSENTIALS

Choose amounts for the trip and likely delays using current local guidance. Do not overload a bag to meet a one-size-fits-all quantity.

- ☐ **Water:** sealed drinking water in containers the carrier can manage; add a cup or drinking aid if needed
- ☐ **Food:** ready-to-eat, shelf-stable foods household members can safely eat; manual can opener and utensils if needed
- ☐ **Clothing:** change of clothes, underwear, sturdy footwear, and weather layers
- ☐ **Light:** flashlight or headlamp—prefer this to candles
- ☐ **Information:** battery-powered or hand-crank radio that receives local emergency broadcasts
- ☐ **Power:** correct spare batteries and charging cables; tested power bank if used
- ☐ **Hygiene:** soap or sanitizer, toothbrush and paste, toilet paper, menstrual products, diapers, incontinence supplies, masks, and sealed waste bags as needed
- ☐ **Basic first aid:** household-sized first-aid kit and instructions; gloves and any items household members know how to use

△ CAUTION — PREVENT HARM

Prevent battery fires: Follow the device and battery maker's charging, temperature, and storage instructions. Keep batteries dry and protect loose battery terminals from metal objects, such as keys, with their original package, a case, or nonconductive tape. Do not pack a swollen, leaking, damaged, or recalled battery or power bank. Never put gasoline, propane cylinders, camp-stove fuel, or other fuel in a go-bag.

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Go-Bag Checklist — continued

2. MEDICINES, HEALTH, AND ACCESSIBILITY

Ask a pharmacist, prescriber, equipment supplier, and insurer how to build and rotate a lawful emergency supply. Storage requirements and refill rules differ; do not stop treatment or change a dose to make a supply last.

- ☐ Essential prescription and over-the-counter medicines, stored exactly as the label or pharmacist directs and secured from children and animals
- ☐ Copies of current prescriptions; pharmacy, prescriber, and equipment-supplier details
- ☐ Paper medical summary: medicine names, doses and schedules; allergies; conditions; treatment and communication needs; emergency contact
- ☐ Glasses, contacts and supplies, hearing-aid batteries, mobility-device parts, syringes, testing supplies, dressings, or other daily health supplies
- ☐ Assistive communication tools, instructions for helpers, and a backup method that does not require internet service
- ☐ Backup-power plan for each essential device: device and connector, safe compatible battery or power bank, charge time, expected run time, and where to recharge
- ☐ Plan for temperature-controlled medicine or equipment; use only storage methods approved by the label, pharmacist, or manufacturer

Medicine/device that cannot go in the bag: _____

Who retrieves or carries it: _____ Backup: _____

3. DOCUMENTS, CONTACTS, ACCESS, AND PAYMENT

Carry copies rather than irreplaceable originals when copies will work. Protect paper from water; protect digital copies with strong access controls. Do not put account passwords or PINs on a label.

- ☐ Identification needed by each person and recent household photos
- ☐ Health, home/renter, vehicle, life, and other relevant insurance information
- ☐ Protected copies or offline records for prescriptions, vital records, accounts, property, vehicles, and animals
- ☐ Printed emergency contacts, out-of-area contact, meeting places, medical contacts, schools, caregivers, veterinarian, and utility or service providers
- ☐ Paper local and regional maps with evacuation destinations and alternate routes marked
- ☐ House, vehicle, gate, storage, and device keys or access items that will be needed
- ☐ A limited amount of securely stored small bills and coins, plus only the payment cards needed; choose an amount that fits the household's plan and risk

Go-Bag Checklist — continued

4. PEOPLE AND ANIMALS

Pack only the lines that apply, using familiar items that are safe for the intended person or animal.

- ☐ **Infant or child:** feeding supplies, diapers, wipes, clothing, medicines, identification, caregiver contacts, quiet activity, and compact comfort item
- ☐ **Pet:** food, water, medicine, bowls, waste supplies, identification, photo, vaccination/medical records, and a safe carrier, leash, or harness
- ☐ **Service animal:** food, water, medicine, bowls, waste supplies, identification and records, working gear, and backup leash or harness
- ☐ **Individual needs:** translated or picture instructions, communication cards, ear protection, sensory aids, religious or cultural items, adaptive utensils, and a compact comfort item

Animal-friendly destination/backup: _____

Item that must stay with its user: _____

5. SEASONAL AND LOCAL-HAZARD ADDITIONS

Check local emergency-management guidance; conditions and permitted equipment vary by place and season.

- ☐ Hot weather: sun protection, cooling aid, light clothing, and additional drinking needs identified by local guidance
- ☐ Cold weather: warm layers, hat, gloves, dry socks, blanket, and traction aids if appropriate
- ☐ Rain, flood, or storm: rain layer, waterproof document pouch, extra dry layer, and local route information
- ☐ Smoke, dust, or poor air: correctly sized respiratory protection recommended by public-health officials; eye protection if locally advised
- ☐ Earthquake, wildfire, severe weather, power shutoff, or other local hazard: _____
- ☐ Seasonal medicine, allergy, mobility, animal, school, or work need: _____

Go-Bag Checklist — continued

6. MAKE THE BAGS MOVABLE AND FINDABLE

Test the complete load without risking a fall, strain, or loss of balance. Split supplies, use a wheeled option, or arrange help when one bag is too heavy.

- ☐ Label the outside with the owner's name or household identifier and a safe callback method—no diagnosis, account details, or other unnecessary private information
- ☐ Put a contact card inside and mark which medicines, devices, or animal supplies must remain with their user
- ☐ Store the bag where its carrier can reach it quickly, away from heat, moisture, pests, and household chemicals; do not block an exit
- ☐ Make sure straps, handles, wheels, and closures work and reflective markings are visible if used
- ☐ Weigh the packed bag and have the assigned person test moving it along the planned exit route
- ☐ Assign every bag, child/animal carrier, device, and item that cannot be prepacked; name a backup carrier
- ☐ Tell household members and helpers where bags are kept; return used items promptly

Bag or separate item	Storage location	Weight	Primary carrier	Backup carrier
_____	_____	____	_____	_____
_____	_____	____	_____	_____
_____	_____	____	_____	_____
_____	_____	____	_____	_____

Go-Bag Checklist — continued

7. DATED MAINTENANCE PANEL

Review after any use and whenever needs, seasons, routes, or household members change. Set a recurring schedule that matches the shortest manufacturer, medicine, food, and document review interval in the bag.

Check	Date checked	Replace/update by	Initials
Food, water, first aid, hygiene: dates, seals, leaks, fit	_____	_____	_____
Medicines and prescriptions: dates, supply plan, storage	_____	_____	_____
Flashlights, radio, batteries: test and inspect	_____	_____	_____
Phones, power banks, medical backup power: charge, test, inspect	_____	_____	_____
IDs, insurance, records, contacts, maps, keys, payment plan	_____	_____	_____
Clothing, child, animal, accessibility, seasonal items	_____	_____	_____
Bag condition, label, location, weight, carrier assignments	_____	_____	_____

Next full review: ____ / ____ / _____ Reviewed by: _____

Continue the plan: See **EVS-001** for the readiness checklist, **EVS-005** for transportation, **EVS-007** for shelter-in-place planning, and **EVS-010** for accessible evacuation planning.

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Build A Kit,” “Individuals with Disabilities,” “Emergency Financial First Aid Kit,” and “Pets and Animals”; U.S. Food and Drug Administration, “Prepare for Emergencies”; Federal Aviation Administration, “Lithium Battery Safety.” Accessed 2026-09-25.